Nursing Essentials

Priority: Assess gestational age, cervical change, membrane status, infection, bleeding, and maternal / fetal stability before planning treatment.

FOCUS 1

Recognize

- **Preterm:** birth before 37 weeks. Labor involves contractions with cervical change before term.
- **Possible symptoms:** tightening, pelvic pressure, low backache, cramps, or a change in discharge.
- **Assessment:** symptoms alone do not confirm labor; use the ordered obstetric evaluation.

FOCUS 2

Assess membranes

- **Assess:** fluid history, maternal temperature, fetal status, and signs of cord prolapse or infection.
- **Limit unnecessary digital exams:** use the recommended evaluation to reduce infection risk and clarify the diagnosis.
- **PPROM:** preterm prelabor rupture of membranes; management depends on gestational age, infection, and stability.

FOCUS 3

Prepare

- **Corticosteroids:** fetal maturation when the client meets the gestational-age and birth-risk criteria.
- **Tocolysis:** selected short-term delay, often to allow steroids or transfer; it does not cure the underlying problem.
- **Magnesium:** fetal neuroprotection for eligible early preterm birth risk, commonly before 32 weeks, according to protocol.

When delaying birth may be unsafe

Make it stick: The same symptom can lead to a different plan at a different gestational age. Always connect the intervention to age, membrane status, and stability.

Focus	What to know	Nursing application
Escalate	suspected intraamniotic infection, significant hemorrhage, or maternal / fetal deterioration.	Escalate instability
Antibiotics	GBS prophylaxis and PPROM latency therapy have different indications; intact membranes do not justify routine latency antibiotics.	Match antibiotics to indication
Prepare	neonatal consultation, appropriate birth location, and family teaching about the care plan.	Coordinate neonatal support

RED FLAGS · ESCALATE PROMPTLY

Suspected infection, significant bleeding, cord concern, or maternal / fetal deterioration can make delaying birth unsafe.